

4D + Vibing Cheat Sheet

The loop Ask → Run → Look → Adjust → repeat.

That's vibe coding. The 4 Ds are what keep each step honest.

STEP	YOU'RE DOING...	WHICH D
Before you start	Deciding this is worth building	Delegation
Ask	Writing the brief in one plain sentence	Description
Run + Look	Judging what came back	Discernment
Adjust, and after	Owning what happened, saying so	Diligence

Delegation

BEFORE YOU TOUCH A KEYBOARD

Should this even be a thing I build, or a thing I do myself?

- ☐ What's the actual problem — not “use AI,” a real fifteen minutes that's currently boring, confusing, or hard to picture?
- ☐ Could I do this faster by hand? If yes, do it by hand.
- ☐ What's the cheapest version of this worth trying first?

RED FLAG you're prompting because you can, not because it's the right tool for this problem.

Discernment

JUDGING WHAT COMES BACK

Fluent and correct are not the same property. Judging output is not optional.

- ☐ Does it feel right, or does it just look finished?
- ☐ Would this survive someone else trying it, not just you?
- ☐ If it's confident, ask: confident about what, exactly — and how would I know if it's wrong?
- ☐ Trust what you see running over your model of the code underneath it

RED FLAG you stopped looking because the output sounded good.

Description

WRITING THE ASK

A brief that fits in one sentence beats a brief that fits in a paragraph.

- ☐ Say the vibe, not the algorithm: “nervous houseplant,” not “write conditional logic for anxiety.”
- ☐ Give it a role, an audience, a constraint — pick one, not all three
- ☐ One example beats three adjectives
- ☐ Fork something that already runs, rather than starting blank

TRY “I want it to feel ____.” Fill the blank before you write anything else.

Diligence

OWNING IT AFTERWARD

The step everyone skips under time pressure.

- ☐ What did I actually use AI for? Could I say so out loud?
- ☐ What broke, and what did I learn from the break?
- ☐ Which fork did I abandon, and why — worth a one-line note for next time
- ☐ Is there a next person (a colleague, a student, future-you) who'll need this record?

RED FLAG you can't remember which version you ended up shipping, or why.

The whole loop, worked small

“I want a machine that confidently invents a stranger's biography from nothing.”

- Delegation** — worth building: makes hallucination concrete in 30 seconds, better than any slide.
- Description** — one sentence, above. Fork the sensor-bridge standalone.
- Discernment** — run it three ways (lie detector / vitals monitor / fire alarm). Which produces the sharpest moment?
- Diligence** — fire alarm won. Write down why. Keep the other two frames as backups.

When to stop vibing and start reading

Some things aren't judged by feel:

- A cryptic error, not a wrong answer
- Camera/mic permissions, API keys, rate limits
- Anything you'd be uncomfortable explaining to a student who asked “wait, how does that actually work?”

That's not a failure of vibing. That's the diligence part of the job.